Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Daniel

Daniel 1:1

Jehoiakim was king of Judah from 609 to 598 BC. Before this siege, he served Egypt as a vassal (a ruler who had to obey a stronger nation). His rule in Judah was very wicked (2 Kings 23:36–24:6; 2 Chronicles 36:5–8; Jeremiah 25). The exile and captivity of Daniel and his friends in 605 BC foreshadowed the exile of the rest of the nation in 597 and 586 BC (see 2 Kings 24:1–25:21). The Lord used King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon as an unknowing servant to achieve his purposes (compare Jeremiah 25:9; 27:6).

Daniel 1:1–2

These verses explain why Daniel and his friends were in Babylon. They briefly describe the setting in which Daniel lived during the years of exile.

Daniel 1:1–21

God kept his promise by sending his rebellious people into exile (see Jeremiah 25:11–12; 29:10). He also showed grace to a small group (a remnant) in exile, protecting and helping Daniel and three other young Hebrew captives. These young men received the best training available in the Babylonian king's court. This prepared them to be God's witnesses in Babylon. They made the God of Israel known even while in exile.

Daniel 1:1–6.28

The first half of Daniel shows the experiences and wisdom of Daniel and his three Hebrew friends. It demonstrates that God is the ruler of the world. It also shows that God's people should stay faithful and act wisely in every situation.

Daniel 1:2

- The Lord, who has complete power and authority over history, gave the victory to Nebuchadnezzar. It was not accomplished by the king's might or the power of his god Marduk, the main god of the Babylonians. The Lord used the exile in Babylon to judge and discipline his people, as he had warned in the Law (for example, Deuteronomy 28:64) and by the prophets (for example, Jeremiah 25:8–14).
- The sacred objects were dedicated for use in the temple of God built by Solomon. After nearly seventy years in Marduk's treasure-house, Belshazzar further defiled these vessels in 539 BC (Daniel 5:1–4). They were later returned to the rebuilt temple during Ezra's time (Ezra 1:7–11; 5:13–16).
- the land of Shinar: Israel's rebellion brought them back to where rebellious humanity had built the Tower of Babel (Genesis 11:2).

Daniel 1:3

chief of his court: Though often translated as "eunuchs" (compare Isaiah 39:7), here the Hebrew term (saris) likely means that Ashpenaz and those under his authority were high government officials (see 2 Kings 8:6).

Daniel 1:3–7

The Lord carried out his warning that sons of the royal family would serve in Babylon (Isaiah 39:7), even though they were heirs to the promises given to King David and his family. Nebuchadnezzar tried hard to convert them through education, social and religious pressure, and name changes. However, their influence on their pagan surroundings became the most notable aspect of their time at the king's palace and court.

Daniel 1:4

- without blemish: They had no defects or blemishes that would disqualify them. The Lord required the same for Israel's priests (Leviticus 21:16–24; 22:17–25). These youths had the wisdom, knowledge, understanding, and character needed to work in high government positions.
- Babylon had a wide range of literature that covered many kinds of knowledge. It included:
- wisdom and secret writings,
- creation stories,
- magic spells,
- theogonies (origins and family trees of the gods),
- legal texts,
- ancient histories,
- letters,
- dream journals,
- guides for interpreting visions, and
- mathematical and astrological materials.

The education of these young men, all in a foreign language, was as advanced as that of Moses in Egypt.

Daniel 1:5

The king tried to make them dependent, grateful, and loyal by giving them food and wine from his kitchens.

Daniel 1:6–7

Their new Babylonian names were meant to help bring the young Hebrews into Babylonian culture. Daniel, whose name means "God is my Judge" or "God has judged," became Belteshazzar, which means "Bel [a

Babylonian god] protects his life." Hananiah, whose name means "the Lord is grace," became Shadrach, which may mean "command of Aku," another Babylonian god. Mishael, whose name means "who is God?" became Meshach, which means "who is Aku?" Azariah, whose name means "the Lord helps," became Abednego, which means "servant of Nego/Nebo," another Babylonian god.

Daniel 1:8

Daniel made up his mind that he would not defile himself: The meat and wine from Nebuchadnezzar's table were likely not allowed by Jewish standards. The Babylonians used meats like pork, which were unclean (see Leviticus 11:1–23; Deuteronomy 14:1–21), and their meat and wine were probably offered to Babylonian gods. The other young Hebrews agreed with Daniel (Daniel 1:12–16). They trusted God and followed his commands, and God blessed them (compare Deuteronomy 28:1–14).

Daniel 1:8–14

Daniel decided not to eat the king's food or drink his wine. He wanted to keep his religious and moral independence. He allowed God to show kindness and care to his faithful servants. This strong trust in God by Daniel and his friends is an important theme in the book (see also Daniel 2:16–23; 3:16–18; 6:16).

Daniel 1:9

God helped Daniel by influencing Ashpenaz's attitude (compare Exodus 11:3).

Daniel 1:10

Ashpenaz was understandably afraid of the king.

Daniel 1:11–13

Daniel found a wise plan that would protect both his faith and Ashpenaz's safety.

Daniel 1:12

only vegetables ... and water: Eating only vegetables and water would avoid forbidden foods (Daniel 1:8). This diet, as a kind of fast, would demonstrate mourning over their exile in a foreign land.

Daniel 1:13–14

deal with your servants: Daniel showed wisdom, careful judgment, and politeness in how he treated his attendant, who reacted positively.

Daniel 1:15–21

During their training, Daniel and his friends followed a challenging curriculum in a threatening pagan culture. They stayed faithful to the Lord. As they learned language, literature, and science, they aimed for excellence and honored God. In return, God enhanced their skills and knowledge with many gifts.

Daniel 1:17

All four young men were excellent students. God gave Daniel the special ability to interpret visions and dreams, which were often prophetic (compare with Joseph, Genesis 37:5–11).

Daniel 1:19

The king spoke with all the young men who were trained, not just Daniel and his three friends. He conducted a thorough oral examination and discussed topics important to him. God chose the four young men to be his witnesses among the nations. They were greatly honored by being appointed to positions of power, responsibility, and opportunity (compare Genesis 41:37–40; 45:5; Exodus 2:1–10).

Daniel 1:20

The magicians were priests who could predict the future and interpret dreams (see Genesis 44:1–15). They could also perform wonders (see Exodus 7:11). The term enchanters, from the Hebrew word 'ashap, appears only in the book of Daniel. It comes from an Akkadian term for people who spoke spells.

Daniel 1:21

the first year of King Cyrus: Cyrus the Great ruled over:

- Persia from 559 to 530 BC,
- Media from 549 BC, and
- Babylon from 539 BC.

He created the Persian Empire, which lasted from 539 to 331 BC (see study notes on Daniel 5:30, 31; compare Isaiah 45:1–2).

Daniel 2:1

second year: If Daniel and his friends' three-year training happened over parts of three calendar years, it might have ended by now (compare Daniel 2:48).

Daniel 2:1–3

Nebuchadnezzar's dream upset him greatly, so he asked his specially trained advisers for help.

Daniel 2:1–49

God gave a dream that showed the course of world history over the centuries, and Daniel explained its mysterious images. This dream and its interpretation highlight a key theme of the book—the certain final establishment of the kingdom of God as the ultimate goal of history (Daniel 2:44–45; 7:9–14, 26–27). This chapter also shows that paganism cannot understand the actions and plans of Israel's God.

Daniel 2:1–6.28

This section contains stories and dreams from the experiences of Daniel and his friends in Babylon. Daniel used his special gift to understand dreams and showed great skill in the study of literature and science (Daniel 1:17). Chapter 2 provides a broad overview of history until God's kingdom appears (Daniel 2:44–49). Daniel 3–6 describes the fall of Babylon and the rise of Persia. History is moving toward a clear goal. That goal is the everlasting kingdom of God (Daniel 2:44; 4:2–3, 34; 6:26).

Daniel 2:2

- magicians, enchanters: See study note on Daniel 1:20.
- Sorcerers were priests who used spoken formulas or ritual actions in their work.
- Astrologers studied the stars and planets to understand the times and seasons of important events.

Daniel 2:3

I have had a dream, and my spirit is anxious: The king feared that other groups might try to remove him from power, so the dream made him very anxious.

Daniel 2:4

- Aramaic had been established by the Assyrians as the common language used for international communication. The Babylonians continued this practice.
- Tell your servants the dream: The Babylonian wise men needed to know the contents of the dream so that they could look them up in their reference books. They did not depend on divine revelation.

Daniel 2:9

Only someone with power that goes beyond human ability could tell Nebuchadnezzar what he had dreamed (compare Mark 2:9–12). No human wisdom or skill could reveal the dream without first hearing it.

Daniel 2:10–11

The Babylonian wise men could explain dreams, but they could not repeat a dream unless someone first told it to them. They also knew that only a divine being could do such a thing (see Daniel 2:17–23, 27–28).

Daniel 2:12

The king was furious because contradicting or refusing his command was an offense punishable by death. eople were expected to treat the king like a god. By saying he was not, they broke the rules of the king's court.

The king's sages were also expected to have a connection with the divine, but they admitted they did not. The offense against the king was so severe that he ordered all the wise men of Babylon to be executed. The king's anger points ahead to the events described in Daniel 11:11–35.

Daniel 2:16

Daniel's ability to visit the king immediately shows his authority and influence. He wisely used gentle words to calm anger at the royal court (compare Proverbs 15:1).

Daniel 2:17–23

With faith and wisdom, Daniel prayed for God to intervene (compare Philippians 4:6). When God answered his prayer, Daniel praised God for giving him wisdom and knowledge (see Daniel 2:20–21). The God of heaven revealed the dream and its meaning, showing his power over all other gods, including the gods of Babylon.

Daniel 2:18

Daniel asked for God's mercy (see Exodus 34:6–7). God did not have to answer Daniel's prayer, but answering it would fit with God's character.

Daniel 2:20–23

Daniel praised Israel's God, the God of his ancestors, as the source of the dream and its meaning (Daniel 2:23).

Daniel 2:21

The dream showed that the Lord rules over all history with complete power and authority (see Daniel 2:29–45).

Daniel 2:24

Daniel's influence with Arioch shows his wisdom and importance in the royal service.

Daniel 2:25

- Babylon held captives from nations other than Judah.
- Daniel, a descendant of Abraham, shared God's revelation with the Babylonian king (see Genesis 12:3).

Daniel 2:26

Are you able to tell me: Nebuchadnezzar was surprised that someone who was not Babylonian had this ability. The Babylonian religion and culture valued their own wise men as "interpreters of the heavens."

Daniel 2:27–28

Daniel emphasized that no human could accomplish what was needed (compare Daniel 2:10–11; see also Genesis 41:16).

Daniel 2:28

- a God in heaven: Daniel spoke of one true God who rules everything (Daniel 2:20–21), unlike the local gods the Babylonians worshiped. The God of Daniel's ancestors (Daniel 2:23) is the God in heaven who reveals secrets. The Babylonian gods could not do this.
- what will happen: In ancient times, people often believed dreams revealed the future.

Daniel 2:29–30

God revealed the future to the king. Nebuchadnezzar was very interested in history. He studied the past and wanted to be part of history's future. God wanted Nebuchadnezzar to understand how history would develop. God may have wanted him to see that Israel's God, the God of heaven, is the God who rules over all history.

Daniel 2:31–33

The progression downward shows a decrease in value: from the most valuable, gold (Daniel 2:32), to the least valuable, iron and baked clay (2:33).

Daniel 2:32–33

- There were different types of gold. Fine gold was the best quality.
- thighs: The area above the knees.
- legs: The area below the knees.

Daniel 2:34

The phrase became a great mountain is implied (compare Daniel 2:35), but is not in the Aramaic text.

Daniel 2:35

filled the whole earth: Compare Genesis 1:28; Exodus 1:7; Matthew 28:18–20. This new kingdom would replace all other kingdoms.

Daniel 2:36–38

king of kings: Nebuchadnezzar ruled over all other empires and their kings. He was the chosen ruler for that period in history (Jeremiah 25:8–9).

Daniel 2:39

inferior to yours: Silver was worth less than gold, just as the chest is lower than the head. Nebuchadnezzar was a very stable ruler who kept the Neo-Babylonian Empire united. In contrast, Persia often faced internal divisions and instability at its borders.

Daniel 2:41–42

partly brittle: Feet are necessary for stability. The brittle feet show how fragile the entire image is. They represent earthly kingdoms and their power.

Daniel 2:43

Just as iron and clay do not mix, marriage between different groups could weaken political alliances instead of creating real or lasting unity. This empire would be divided.

Daniel 2:44

- Those kings likely emerged within the fourth kingdom and tried to gain strength through marriage alliances. However, the phrase might refer to all the kings of the statue as God's kingdom continually influences history.
- will itself stand forever: Only a kingdom with authority and power from God (see John 18:36) can never be destroyed, as all earthly kingdoms eventually fall.

Daniel 2:45

- The Babylonians often pictured the earth as a large mountain or a ziggurat (a tall, stepped temple tower). Because of this, the rock in the dream would be understood as covering or replacing the whole earth.
- The dream is true: The dream was clearly explained through divine revelation, and it came from God.

- its interpretation is trustworthy: God guaranteed that the dream's message would definitely happen.

Daniel 2:46

The Aramaic word segid is sometimes translated as "worshiped," but in this verse, it can also mean "paid him homage or honor." Nebuchadnezzar was a pagan who believed in many gods. He believed that the spirit of the gods was in Daniel (Daniel 4:8; compare 5:11). Because of this, he believed that Daniel's abilities came from a powerful divine spirit, not from ordinary human skill (compare Genesis 41:38).

Daniel 2:47

God of gods and Lord of kings: Nebuchadnezzar returned the honor Daniel had given him (Daniel 2:37–38). He acknowledged through his words and actions (Daniel 2:46) that God is supreme over all, even over Nebuchadnezzar himself.

Daniel 2:48

Daniel became the ruler of Babylon as the king's deputy (compare Genesis 41:37–46).

Daniel 2:49

Daniel gave the responsibility for governing the province to his three friends. This allowed him to remain in the king's court and serve as the king's advisor.

Daniel 3:1

- The plain of Dura may have been the plain next to the city of Babylon. Another possibility is that the Aramaic term refers to the great outer wall of Babylon described by the Greek historian Herodotus.
- statue: This word means "image."

Daniel 3:1–30

Nebuchadnezzar's obsession with power might have been fueled by the vision in Daniel 2. This obsession led him to build a golden statue and order everyone in his empire to worship it. He did not understand that God cannot be contained in any created object.

The three young Hebrews refused to worship the statue as a god. They remained faithful to the Lord, and the Lord saved them from the king's anger.

Daniel 3:2

The various classes of people listed here were all governmental officials.

Daniel 3:5

Pipes might be translated as "drums," or this could be a musical term meaning to be "in harmony" with the other instruments.

Daniel 3:7

all the people: Outside of Israel, idol worship was common. So, all the non-Jewish people obeyed the king's command.

Daniel 3:11

In some situations, the Lord's people must refuse to obey the established authorities in order to remain faithful to the Lord (compare Acts 4:19; 5:29; Romans 13:1–7).

Daniel 3:12

These Jews had disobeyed the king by refusing to worship his statue. Disobeying the king was considered an act of high treason (see Daniel 2:10–13).

Daniel 3:13

Nebuchadnezzar could become very angry, even with his most honored officials (compare Daniel 2:12, 48–49).

Daniel 3:14

is it true: The Aramaic word hatzdā' appears only here in the Old Testament. The king might have been asking, "Are you doing this on purpose?"

Daniel 3:15

Now when ... very good: The three men may have received a second chance because they had previously served the king and had a good relationship with him.

Daniel 3:16–18

The three men declared their loyalty to God above all else. They trusted the God who had saved the entire nation of Israel from Pharaoh's power (Exodus 18:10). God later showed that those who stay faithful until death will be saved even after they have died (Daniel 12:1–3).

Daniel 3:23

In the Greek version and the Latin Vulgate, The Prayer of Azariah and The Song of the Three Jews appear after Daniel 3:23 (see Daniel Book Introduction, "Author and Date").

Daniel 3:25

- walking around: The same word appears in Genesis 3:8–9.
- like a son of the gods!: The king understood the being to be the Lord's angel (Daniel 3:28).

Daniel 3:26

The title Most High often refers to God in religious texts (for example, Daniel 4:2, 24–25; 7:25; Genesis 14:18; Numbers 24:16; Deuteronomy 32:8–9; Psalm 73:11; Isaiah 14:14). In Canaanite religion, it often referred to Baal.

Daniel 3:28

The king was surprised that God could rescue his people. However, the three Hebrew men knew their God could rescue them (Daniel 3:17).

Daniel 3:30

promoted: A similar word appears in Genesis 39:2. The men received rewards for their righteousness and faithfulness to the Lord.

Daniel 4:1–37

King Nebuchadnezzar was full of pride and believed he had built Babylon by himself (Daniel 4:30; see Genesis 11:1–9). He ignored the warning from the Most High God (Daniel 4:24–27). He had not learned the lesson that God was teaching him, that the God of Daniel exists beyond time and space, and no human is his equal. So, God's judgment came upon Nebuchadnezzar (Daniel 4:17, 25–26; see Proverbs 16:18).

Daniel 4:4

God did not let the king remain in the comfort and prosperity of his palace. Injustice and oppression were in the city (Daniel 4:27), and the king was very proud (4:30).

Daniel 4:5

Nebuchadnezzar's dream disrupted the false peace and calm in the king's misguided life.

Daniel 4:7

- The professionals could not interpret the dream, even though it was explained to them this time (compare Daniel 2:1–11). Their dream manuals did not help (see study note on Daniel 2:4).
- astrologers: See also Daniel 2:5, 10; 3:8; 5:7, 11, 30.

Daniel 4:8–9

- at last: Nebuchadnezzar first asked his Babylonian advisers for help. Even though Daniel held a high position, he was an exiled Jew, and the king turned to him only as a last resort.
- in whom is the spirit of the holy gods: See Daniel 2:47; compare 5:11. Despite his past experiences with the Most High God, Nebuchadnezzar still believed in many gods. In Egypt, Pharaoh said the same thing about Joseph (Genesis 41:37–38).

The Most High God helped Daniel (Daniel 4:24). However, the great king's statement that Daniel had the spirit of the holy gods showed great respect and explains why Daniel was not harassed (see Daniel 3).

Daniel 4:11

The top of the tree reached high into the sky. This might refer to the Tower of Babel (Genesis 11:1–9).

Daniel 4:13

a holy one: The word holy is not widely used in Semitic languages outside the Bible. In those contexts, it usually refers to something unusual or nonhuman. Nebuchadnezzar was most likely using the word in this sense here.

Daniel 4:14–17

The messenger had complete authority as God's representative to announce God's decrees and demand that they be fulfilled.

Daniel 4:16

- Seven periods of time might mean seven years (compare Daniel 7:25; 9:24–25).
- mind of a beast: See Daniel 4:31–33.

Daniel 4:17

the Most High rules: God gives kingship and kingdoms to anyone he chooses, even the lowliest (for example, Joseph, Genesis 41:41–57; David, 1 Samuel 16–2 Samuel 5).

Daniel 4:22

- The tree provides food, rest, and safety for the world (compare Genesis 2:15–17; Revelation 22:14).
- your greatness has grown to reach the sky: Compare Genesis 11:1–9.

Daniel 4:23

Cut down the tree: They must cut down the tree because of Nebuchadnezzar's pride (Daniel 4:27–30).

Daniel 4:25–26

until you acknowledge that the Most High rules: God's purpose was for people to see and acknowledge God's rule.

Daniel 4:27

- Break away from your sins by doing what is right: Righteousness and justice make a nation strong and help keep a king's rule stable. When righteousness and justice are missing, a nation will fall. Daniel humbly pleaded with the king to change his ways.
- showing mercy to the oppressed: This was required by God's law (Exodus 23:6–11; Deuteronomy 15:10–11; Proverbs 29:14; 31:9) and Babylon's. Hammurabi was a former great king of Babylon. He ruled from about 1792 to 1750 BC. Hammurabi claimed to have been charged by his god Marduk to shepherd and protect the orphaned, the widowed, and the oppressed.
- Perhaps: Daniel understood that God could choose to act or not (compare Daniel 3:16–18). Because God is merciful, he might pity the condemned king (compare Exodus 32:30; 1 Samuel 14:6; 2 Samuel 12:22; Joel 2:14; Amos 5:15; Zephaniah 2:3; 2 Timothy 2:25).

Daniel 4:28–33

Because the king did not listen to Daniel's warning, the dream came true.

Daniel 4:30

The city of Babylon had magnificent walls adorned with royal blue ceramic tiles and gold-colored lions and dragons. The Hanging Gardens of Babylon added to the city's splendor, along with the bright and impressive Ishtar Gate. The king saw all of this as a reflection of his own glory and power, not as a gift from the Most High God.

Daniel 4:32

The king who exiled Israel for seventy years faced his own seven-year exile until he overcame his pride.

Daniel 4:33

Boanthropy is a disease that makes a person act like an ox. Several ancient writings support this story. The king's official records are also empty from 582 to 575 BC, which may fit this period of illness.

Daniel 4:34–37

Nebuchadnezzar now recognized and submitted to the greater authority of the Most High, the King of heaven.

Daniel 4:35

He does as He pleases: God has complete power in heaven and on earth.

Daniel 4:37

The Most High God rules both heaven and earth. Human pride has no place before God, not even the pride of the greatest human kings.

Daniel 5:1

- Later: This chapter begins with events that took place in October 539 BC (see study note on Daniel 5:30).
- The name Belshazzar means "Bel Protects [the King]." Bel was a Babylonian god. Nabonidus, who ruled from 556 to 539 BC, placed his son Belshazzar on the Babylonian throne around 553 BC to rule in his place. Nabonidus then moved to Tema in northwest Arabia, where he stayed for ten years. He returned to Babylon only in a failed attempt to resist the Persians (see Daniel 5:30–31).

Daniel 5:1–30

All earthly kingdoms eventually end. Nebuchadnezzar's dream suggested that Babylon would fall and a new kingdom would rise (Daniel 2:39).

After Nebuchadnezzar died in 562 BC, violence and corruption grew in Babylon's palaces. During Belshazzar's feast in 539 BC, they even defiled God's holy vessels. God's judgment came quickly that night (Daniel 5:30), and the next kingdom took over (see 2:32, 39; 5:31).

Daniel 5:2–4

- The gold and silver cups from the temple in Jerusalem were taken along with the people (Daniel 1:2), but earlier Babylonian kings did not misuse them. They were eventually returned to Jerusalem (Ezra 1:7–11).
- father: Belshazzar was Nabonidus's oldest son; his connection to Nebuchadnezzar is unclear.
- As they drank the wine, they praised their gods: If Belshazzar ever knew about the respect Nebuchadnezzar showed the Most High God decades earlier (Daniuel 4:34–37), he had forgotten it. Two ancient Greek historians, Herodotus and Xenophon, describe the all-night partying, dancing, and heavy drinking that occurred as Persia captured the city.

Daniel 5:5–6

The supernatural hand shocked and terrified the people at the feast. Yet Belshazzar still did not repent (Daniel 5:29; compare Jeremiah 38:19–24; Acts 24:25).

Daniel 5:7

- Purple robes and a gold chain symbolize royalty and power.
- third highest: This position came after Nabonidus and Belshazzar himself (see study note on Daniel 5:1).

Daniel 5:8

As before, the Babylonian wise men could not interpret the omen (see Daniel 2:4–11; 4:7; 5:15).

Daniel 5:10

- the queen: She was likely Belshazzar's mother, not his wife.
- O king, may you live forever!: This was a common greeting (also in Daniel 2:4). This is ironic because Belshazzar would die that same night (Daniel 5:30).
- Do not let your thoughts terrify you, or your face grow pale: Compare 1 Samuel 28:20–25.

Daniel 5:11–12

The queen mother thought that someone with the spirit of the holy gods, who could interpret dreams (see Daniel 1:17), should also interpret the writing.

Daniel 5:15

None of the Babylonian wise men could understand the heavenly code (compare Daniel 2:27; 4:7). Only true wise men or prophets can interpret God's messages. Daniel knew that the spirit of God enabled him to do so (compare Daniel 2:28; 5:24).

Daniel 5:17

Daniel explained the writing but did not accept payment from the wicked king (see also Genesis 14:21–24; 2 Kings 5:15–16).

Daniel 5:18–21

Daniel used Nebuchadnezzar as an example that should have guided the kings who came after him. But Belshazzar repeated the same mistake. He lifted himself up and dishonored the Most High God.

Daniel 5:20

A person who rebels against God often has a heart and mind filled with arrogance (or a hardened heart; see Exodus 7:13; Joshua 11:20; Isaiah 14:3–5). Nebuchadnezzar was humbled when he became arrogant, and the same would happen to Belshazzar.

Daniel 5:21

the Most High God rules ... over it whom He wishes: God taught Nebuchadnezzar this lesson, and it was central to God's message to Belshazzar. God would appoint a new ruler that very night (Daniel 5:30–31).

Daniel 5:25–28

MENE, MENE, TEKEL, PARSIN: These Aramaic units of measure are used on a balance to weigh goods being bought and sold. Belshazzar knew the words, but Daniel explained their meaning in this context. The God of Israel measures kings and kingdoms using the balances of justice and righteousness (compare Daniel 4:27).

Daniel 5:26

MENE means that God has numbered the days: In this context, it means that God had examined and evaluated Belshazzar's reign

Daniel 5:27

TEKEL means that you have been weighed ... and found deficient: Babylon's king would face destruction because he did not meet God's demand for righteousness and mercy (see Daniel 4:27; 5:22–24).

Daniel 5:28

PERES means that your kingdom has been divided: God would divide the Babylonian Empire and give it to two peoples, the Medes and the Persians.

Daniel 5:29

- Instead of replying to the message, Belshazzar honored Daniel.
- proclaimed him the third highest ruler: Daniel did not want the honor, and it would soon be meaningless. God would reward Daniel at the right time (Daniel 12:13).

Daniel 5:30

The Medes and Persians conquered Babylon, which began a new era of Persian rule.

Daniel 5:31

Darius the Mede is distinct from later Persian kings named Darius (see "The Medes and Persians" Profile). Cyrus the Great conquered Babylon in 539 BC, and

there is no mention of a Darius the Mede in other sources. Two solutions are possible:

1. Cyrus the Great might have chosen Darius the Mede to rule as "King of Babylon" in his place for a little over a year (compare Dan 6:28; 9:1; 11:1).
2. Darius and Cyrus might have been the same man bearing two throne names—one name from the Medes, the other from the Persians (see also study note on 6:28).

The portrayal of Darius in ch 6 suggests that he was in fact Cyrus, the ruler of all Media, Persia, and Babylonia.

Daniel 6:1–28

God saved and freed his loyal servant Daniel (Daniel 5:23; 6:20), but Belshazzar's lifeless gods could not help him.

Daniel 6:2

- The king appointed three administrators to oversee the entire territory.
- so that the king would not suffer loss: They needed to be completely trustworthy to prevent rebels from threatening the empire.

Daniel 6:3

the king planned to set him over the whole kingdom: Compare Daniel 2:48–49; 3:30; Genesis 41:40–43.

Daniel 6:3–5

Daniel's integrity was beyond question, and his abilities were unmatched. The envious administrators targeted his strongest point, his faithful worship of God. Daniel was about 80 to 85 years old at this time. He had lived an exemplary life in Babylon.

Daniel 6:5

law of his God: Compare Daniel 6:8, 12, 15; Ezra 7:12, 14, 25.

Daniel 6:7

- the king should establish an ordinance: The request seemed to appeal to truth and justice, but it actually targeted the king's pride with hidden motives (Daniel 6:4–5).
- We already know that Daniel would not disobey God's law to follow a human command (compare Daniel 1:5–8; 3:4–12).

Daniel 6:8

cannot be changed ... cannot be repealed: Compare Esther 1:19. Human laws do not last forever, but God's law does (Psalms 93:5; 119:152). This devotion to established laws was a key feature of the Persian Empire. Over time, the large number of laws made the government so complex that it could no longer work well.

Daniel 6:10–11

- just as he had done before: Daniel's regular prayer time helped him worship God daily.
- Jerusalem was God's chosen city (1 Kings 11:36). Even though the temple was gone, forgetting Jerusalem was unthinkable (Psalm 137:5–6). Someday, the temple would be rebuilt (Isaiah 2:2–4; 44:28).

Daniel 6:14

- The king had not considered all the consequences of signing the law.
- deeply distressed: Or very angry because he felt tricked. He did not want to execute his best servant.

Daniel 6:16

The king was trapped by the officials and had to enforce the law. However, he respected Daniel's honesty in worshiping his God (compare Daniel 3:15; 6:20).

Daniel 6:17

his own signet ring and with the rings of his nobles: Sealing the lions' den with multiple seals made a secret rescue impossible. The king and officials could not open the den without breaking the seals and alerting others.

Daniel 6:18

The king fasted all night. He mourned his actions and hoped Daniel's God would save him. He could not sleep, knowing Daniel was innocent and noble.

Daniel 6:19

At the first light of dawn: This means the earliest possible hour of the day.

Daniel 6:20

- has your God ... been able: There was no doubt that Daniel had served God faithfully. So, if God did not rescue him, it would have shown the king that God could not do so.
- living God: The king likely knew what Daniel's God had done during the reigns of Nebuchadnezzar and

Belshazzar. The term living God is used in the Bible to compare the Lord with lifeless idols (see, for example, Deuteronomy 5:26; Joshua 3:10; Isaiah 37:17–18).

Daniel 6:21–22

My God sent his angel: The law of the Medes and Persians was powerless. God can protect his loyal servant and his own reputation.

Daniel 6:25–27

King Darius wrote: Like Nebuchadnezzar before him (compare Daniel 3:28–29; 4:34–37), the current ruler of the civilized world declared to all his subjects that Daniel's God is alive, powerful, and has an eternal kingdom.

Daniel 6:27

He delivers and rescues ... He has rescued Daniel: This proclamation moves from the general to the specific. Daniel was a specific example of God's rescuing power. God continues to act on behalf of his people, just as he has always done.

Daniel 6:28

the reign of Darius and the reign of Cyrus the Persian: Or the reign of Darius, which means the reign of Cyrus the Persian. This use of "and" is common in Aramaic. Many believe Cyrus and Darius were the same person (see study note on Daniel 5:31).

Daniel 7:1

- In the first year of the reign of Belshazzar: This vision happened before the events in Daniel 6.
- Daniel recorded this vision.

Daniel 7:1–28

This chapter includes a frightening vision (Daniel 7:2–14) and its explanation (7:17–27). The order of kingdoms reminds us of Nebuchadnezzar's dream about forty-five years earlier (Daniel 2:1–45).

Daniel 7:1–12.13

The second half of the book contains visions given to Daniel. These visions assured Daniel and his people, both those in exile and those who had returned to Judea, that God controls the future. All empires will eventually fall before the kingdom of heaven. Daniel's people will be saved from their troubles (Daniel 12:1–3), and God will resurrect and judge all people (see 12:13). Daniel interpreted these visions with help from divine messengers (Daniel 7:10; 8:15; 9:22; 10:14; 12:7).

Daniel 7:2

In the Old Testament, the sea symbolizes evil or chaos (see Psalm 89:10; Isaiah 5:30; 57:20). This view was common in the ancient Near East.

Daniel 7:3–7

The kingdoms of the world are shown as four large beasts (Daniel 7:17; compare Revelation 13:1–2).

Daniel 7:4

- The lion and eagle are respected rulers in their worlds. Lions often appeared in ancient art and buildings. Nebuchadnezzar and Babylon are shown as a lion and an eagle attacking Edom (Jeremiah 49:19, 22).
- it was ... given the mind of a man: Nebuchadnezzar had the mind of a beast (Daniel 4:16, 32–33), but he was restored and learned to honor the Most High God (4:34–37).

Daniel 7:5

- The second beast likely represents Persia (Daniel 2:34–40; 6:9, 12, 15; 8:20).
- The bear was known for its fierce attacks (Proverbs 28:15). The three ribs might symbolize Babylon, Media, and Lydia, which Cyrus conquered.
- flesh: God chose Cyrus and Persia to conquer many nations (Isaiah 41:2–3; 44:28; 45:1, 13; 46:11).

Daniel 7:6

The leopard was famous for its speed and agility (Habakkuk 1:8). Four bird wings and four heads show the range and speed of this fierce nation's military campaigns. Greece fit this symbolism well, especially under Alexander the Great. After he died in 323 BC, his kingdom was divided into four parts.

Daniel 7:7

- The fourth beast was different in kind, not only in degree. It was described as being made of nonliving metal. It was hardly like an animal at all. It was impersonal, completely violent, and without mercy. Even its iron teeth were pictured as a perfect tool for killing. Most commentators, both ancient and modern, see this fourth beast as representing the Roman Empire and its rulers.
- ten horns: In this type of apocalyptic writing, horns can symbolize kings, power, and strength.

Daniel 7:8

Many believe that the fourth kingdom was only partly represented in Rome. They think another, more brutal

kingdom, similar to Rome, will emerge. This kingdom will be led by a final little horn, a powerful and arrogant human being (compare Daniel 8:9–12, 23–25; 9:25–27; 11:36–45; 12:1–7).

Daniel 7:9–10

- The kingdoms of the world are represented by fierce animals. The kingdom of God is represented by a divine-human figure (also in Daniel 7:13–14) and by holy people.
- the Ancient One: This name refers to God, who existed before all nations and peoples.
- White hair and clothing symbolize wisdom and purity. The river of fire represents God's purifying presence.

Daniel 7:10

- Together, the millions and many millions suggest numbers beyond what can be counted.
- the books: God keeps records and uses them as the basis for his judgment (see Daniel 10:21; 12:1; Exodus 32:32; Psalms 69:28; 139:16; Malachi 3:16; Philippians 4:3; Revelation 20:12, 15; 21:27).

Daniel 7:11

God's judgment caused the fourth beast to be destroyed by fire.

Daniel 7:12

a season and a time: God, the Judge of the nations, can extend the lives of nations and individuals (compare Daniel 4:27). Defeated nations that have lost their political and military dominance can continue to exist culturally and ethnically, maintaining their national identities. This occurred with the Assyrians, the Babylonians, the Persians, and the Greeks.

Daniel 7:13

- like the Son of Man: He was like a human being (compare Daniel 3:25).
- His arrival with the clouds of heaven suggests that he was a divine being (see Psalms 68:4; 97:2; Matthew 24:30; 26:64; Mark 13:26; 14:62; Luke 21:27; 1 Thessalonians 4:17; Revelation 1:7).

Daniel 7:13–14

This being like a son of man, unlike the arrogant little horn, did not boast and was not violent. He did not overthrow other kings by force and received God's favor and blessing. He was led into God's presence and presented to Him. God gave him kingship and a kingdom. This figure is the Messiah, God's chosen and anointed king.

Daniel 7:14

Unlike earthly rulers and kingdoms that eventually end, his rule lasts forever and will never be destroyed. His kingdom is given to the holy people of the Most High (Daniel 7:27), and it fills the earth (2:35, 44–45).

Daniel 7:15–16

Daniel bravely approached the beings next to God's throne, and they helped him instead of harming him.

Daniel 7:17

These four great beasts are four kings: God gave Daniel a vision of history's course, which no human could achieve. These kingdoms from the earth (see Daniel 7:2) are human, not heavenly.

Daniel 7:18

- The holy people (also in Daniel 7:21–22, 25, 27) are those who belong only to God and share his character. In Daniel's time, this referred to the people of Israel.
- Only the Most High God can declare how history will end. Other ancient writers spoke of the ages or eras of earthly history, but none knew how it would end.

Daniel 7:19–28

Daniel requested and received more information about the fourth beast, the ten horns, and the little horn.

Daniel 7:21

The target of the little horn's hatred and pride was God's holy people. In this way, the little horn was similar to Pharaoh and Haman (see Exodus 1:22; Esther 3:8–9; compare Daniel 11:36–40).

Daniel 7:22

The Ancient of Days changed the course of the conflict when he judged in favor of his holy people. In God's time, his people would receive the kingdom together with their King (Daniel 7:13–14).

Daniel 7:24–25

- the ten horns are ten kings: This number might refer to ten specific individuals, or it might symbolize that this kingdom lasted through the reigns of many kings (compare Revelation 13:1).

- Then another king, who is the little horn (Daniel 7:21), will defy the Most High. He will oppress the holy people by:
- speaking against the Lord,
- interfering with their worship,
- trying to force them to follow his religion, and
- constantly threatening them.
- a time, and times, and half a time: The text does not clearly state the length of time. However, the period of oppression for the holy people will be limited and will come to an end suddenly and unexpectedly.

Daniel 7:26

God's court has the authority to pass judgment and the power to remove and destroy this proud king.

Daniel 7:27

When this proud king is defeated, God's kingdom will rule forever over all kingdoms on earth (compare Psalm 2; Isaiah 9:6–7). God's holy people of the will serve as leaders in God's kingdom (compare Luke 22:29–30; 1 Corinthians 6:2–3; Revelation 3:21; 20:4).

Daniel 8:1

- The author probably changes back to Hebrew because he focuses again (as with Daniel 1:1–2:4a) on the holy people, Israel, for the rest of the book.
- The third year of King Belshazzar's reign was around 554 to 551 BC. This was about two years after the vision in Daniel 7 and over a decade before Babylon fell in 539 BC (Daniel 5:31).

Daniel 8:1–27

This vision builds on the vision in Daniel 7, developing additional symbolism regarding the second and third beasts (Daniel 7:5–6). It describes a small horn that comes from the goat, similar to the "little horn" in Daniel 7:8, 20–25; the "prince" in 9:26–27; and the "despicable person" in 11:21–45.

Daniel 8:2

- Susa was located in the lowlands southwest of the Zagros Mountains. It was one of Persia's capital cities (compare Ezra 4:9; Nehemiah 1:1; Esther 1:2). Susa was a fortified capital with architecture decorated with glazed images of griffins (creatures with the body of a lion and the head and wings of an eagle), winged bulls, and lions.
- The Ulai River was likely a human-made canal.

Daniel 8:3–4

- Two long horns suggest there were two major nations in this kingdom, represented by a ram (see Daniel 8:20–21).
- God allowed the nation to act freely, but God remained in control (compare Isaiah 45:1–4).

Daniel 8:5–12

Daniel 8:21–25 explains the symbolism.

Daniel 8:10

The heavenly army might mean either:

1. actual divine beings, because the "small horn" tried to destroy Israel's religion, which God protected with His watchful eye and armies; and/or
2. the human defenders of Israel who fought for God's holy people and the temple. These events affected both the physical and spiritual realms.

Daniel 8:11–12

- God commands heaven's army (compare Joshua 5:13–15; 1 Samuel 4:4; 1 Kings 22:19). Daily sacrifices were offered to God in his temple, where his name dwelled, and Israel worshiped their King (Isaiah 18:7; Ezekiel 43:6–7).
- overthrew: The religious function of the temple was stopped.
- God restrained the heavenly army for reasons only he knows.
- The truth of God's law, shown in true worship, was also overthrown (literally cast down).

Daniel 8:13–14

- How long: God's people were called to endure this difficult time until it ended.
- about the 2,300 evenings and mornings: This could either mean a period of 1,150 days (1,150 evenings and 1,150 mornings, about three and a half years) or 2,300 days (about seven years). These times match important events in history:
- In 171 BC, Antiochus IV removed Onias III from his position as high priest.
- In December 167 BC, he treated the temple with disrespect and offered unclean sacrifices.
- In December 164 BC, the temple and the altar were cleansed and used again for proper worship. This was seven years after Onias lost his position, and just over three years after the temple was made unclean (see 1 Maccabees 1:54; 4:52–53; 2 Maccabees 10:5).

- The temple would then be made right for its proper religious use. It would not be rebuilt physically (see 8:11–12; study note on 8:26).

Daniel 8:15–16

The name Gabriel means "man of God." He appeared as a man to Daniel (see also Daniel 9:21; Luke 1:19, 26).

Daniel 8:17

Son of man means "human being," in contrast to a divine being, "a son of the gods" (compare Daniel 7:13; see, for example, Ezekiel 2:1, 3, 6, 8).

Daniel 8:19

the appointed time of the end: There is a set time for history to conclude.

Daniel 8:19–26

These verses explain the vision from Daniel 8:3–14.

Daniel 8:20

The smaller horn represents Media, an independent kingdom starting in 670 BC. The larger horn represents Persia, which controlled Media during Cyrus's reign (see Daniel 7:5).

Daniel 8:21

- The large horn represents Alexander the Great, the mighty first king who established the Greek Empire. Two centuries after Daniel, Alexander quickly conquered the world (Daniel 8:5). He defeated Persia in 331 BC. Alexander died in 323 BC when he was 33 years old. But not before he allowed people to call him a god.
- Josephus records that some Jewish priests showed the book of Daniel to Alexander. However, Alexander treated Homer's Iliad as his sacred book and relied on it for guidance.

Daniel 8:22

After Alexander died in 323 BC, his kingdom was divided into four major kingdoms. His generals ruled these kingdoms (see "The Greeks" Profile).

Daniel 8:23–25

The little horn (Daniel 8:9) was a fierce king. This description fits Antiochus IV, who was a ruler from the Seleucid dynasty from 175 to 163 BC (compare Daniel 11:21–45). He called himself "Epiphanes," which means "The Manifest Presence [of God]." But many people, including Jews, mockingly called him "Epimanes," which means "Mad Man."

By desecrating the temple and Jewish worship (Daniel 8:11–12), Antiochus tried to destroy Judaism and unify his kingdom under Hellenistic culture. Some Jews were influenced by Hellenism and adopted Greek customs.

Daniel 8:24

- His power ... will not be his own: God stayed in control of the events that led Antiochus IV to power.
- terrible destruction: See 1 Maccabees 1:10–63, which describes many of the evils that Antiochus IV caused.

Daniel 8:25

- The Prince of princes is the king of Israel, the ruler of heaven and earth (Daniel 7:9–10, 13–14). At the time of his death, Antiochus exalted himself as God and aimed to destroy Jerusalem.
- he will be broken: Just as Antiochus IV rose to power not by his own strength (Daniel 8:24), he was destroyed by God's hand, not by human power. He met his end by being eaten by worms (1 Maccabees 6:7–16 and 2 Maccabees 9:4–28; compare Herod Agrippa, Acts 12:20–23).

Daniel 8:26

seal up the vision: It would have been unwise for Daniel to share this vision at that time during Belshazzar's reign. Sharing it might have looked like Daniel was planning to rebel or betray the king.

Daniel 9:1

- Darius ... a Mede: See study note on Daniel 5:31.
- Ahasuerus is the Hebrew version of a Persian word, translated into Greek as "Xerxes." The father of Darius the Mede was likely a different Xerxes than Xerxes I, who ruled from 486 to 465 BC (see Esther 1:1). This vision occurred in 539 BC. Some suggest that Xerxes/Ahasuerus was an ancient throne name for Persian kings.

Daniel 9:1–19

Daniel prayed for his people, knowing that Jerusalem's seventy years of desolation were about to end. His prayer is similar to those of:

- Solomon (1 Kings 8:14–61),
- Ezra (Ezra 9), and
- Nehemiah (Nehemiah 9).

God answered Daniel's prayer quickly (see study note on Daniel 9:19; see also Daniel 9:20–27).

Daniel 9:2

- according ... Jeremiah: Daniel likely had a copy of Jeremiah's prophecies.
- the desolation of Jerusalem would last seventy years: Jerusalem was destroyed in 586 BC (see 2 Kings 25:8), and the first return happened in 538 BC. This was about 48 years later. They began rebuilding the city almost immediately (see Ezra 3:1–13; Isaiah 44:28), and the rebuilt temple was completed in 515 BC. This was about 71 years after its destruction (Ezra 6:15). Daniel might have considered Jerusalem's "destruction" as starting with his own exile in 605 BC (see Jeremiah 25:11–12), with 67 years between 605 and 538 BC.

Daniel 9:3

- Daniel realized the seventy years were almost over, so he asked the Lord God to restore his people and Jerusalem.
- People who were mourning often wore rough burlap clothing and placed ashes on themselves as a sign of sorrow (compare Nehemiah 9:1; Esther 4:1; Lamentations 2:10; Luke 10:13).
- Focused prayer often included fasting to prioritize spiritual concerns over physical needs.

Daniel 9:4

- the LORD (Hebrew Yahweh): This is the covenant name of God (Exodus 6:2–3; 20:2) and appears in Daniel only in this chapter.
- God remains faithful to his covenant with those who love and obey him (compare Exodus 34:6–7; Deuteronomy 7:9; Romans 8:28). God's unfailing love is his core nature. The Hebrew word is khesed, which is also sometimes translated as "grace," "mercy," or "kindness." It inspires faith, hope, and worship throughout the Bible (see Numbers 14:18; Nehemiah 9:17; Psalms 108:4; 136:1–26; Jonah 2:4; 1 John 4:7–8).

Daniel 9:4–11

God's faithfulness was very different from his people's unfaithfulness and rebellion. When Daniel confessed his people's sins, he included himself (Daniel 9:5), even though he lived a praiseworthy life (see "Community Identity" Theme Note).

Daniel prayed a high priestly prayer for his people, using many quotes and references from the Torah (the instructions God gave through Moses), the prophets (God's messengers), and the psalms (songs and prayers used in worship).

Daniel 9:5

Daniel used four different words for sin:

- we have sinned (literally missed the mark),
- done wrong (as in, committed a bent or twisted act),
- acted wickedly and rebelled (against the covenant), and
- turned away from Your commandments and ordinances.

Daniel 9:6

God's servants, the prophets, were his specially chosen and inspired messengers (Daniel 9:10; Deuteronomy 18:15–22; 2 Kings 17:23; 21:10–15; Jeremiah 7:25; 25:4).

Daniel 9:7–14

To You, O Lord, belongs righteousness: God planned the exile to judge unfaithful Israel (Daniel 9:11–14). God had warned them many times that it would occur (see Deuteronomy 28:36–37, 49–68).

Daniel 9:12

God sending Israel into exile for breaking his covenant was a unique historical event. Israel's exodus from Egypt, their exile, and their return from Babylon remain unmatched (see also Jeremiah 29:10).

Daniel 9:13

All curses mentioned in the Law of Moses are summarized in Leviticus 26 and Deuteronomy 27–28. When the people entered the covenant, they promised to obey. They called down curses on themselves if they failed (see Exodus 24:7–8; Joshua 8:34–35).

Daniel 9:15

God could bring lasting honor to his name by rescuing his people from exile in Babylonia, just as he did when he saved them from Egypt (compare Ezekiel 36:19–24).

Daniel 9:15–19

Daniel pleaded with God to save his people and end the exile in Babylon. He depended on God's mercy and God's wish to honor his name. Daniel's prayer is one of the great intercessory prayers in which someone speaks to God on behalf of the people in the Old Testament (see also Exodus 32:11–14; Ezra 9:1–15; Nehemiah 9:1–37).

Daniel 9:16

Mocking Jerusalem and its people dishonored God's name. When enemies ridiculed God's chosen city and people, it seemed like their God was powerless (Daniel 9:19; compare Ezekiel 36:19–20).

Daniel 9:17

For Your sake: This means for God's honor (Daniel 9:19).

Daniel 9:18

because of Your great compassion: God's kind and forgiving nature gave Daniel hope (see Exodus 34:6; Jonah 4:1–3; Micah 6:8).

Daniel 9:19

- hear and act! ... do not delay: Daniel prayed this prayer in 539 BC (see study note on Daniel 9:1). Shortly after, in 538 BC, King Cyrus issued a decree allowing the Jewish people to return to Judea (Ezra 1:1–4).

The new temple in Jerusalem was completed in 515 BC (Ezra 6:15). God brought the Israelites back from exile in Babylon because of their prayers and repentance. The exile had been God's response to their sins and rebellion.

- Your city and Your people bear Your name: God's reputation was associated with Jerusalem (Nehemiah 1:9) and his people, Israel (Exodus 5:22–6:1).

Daniel 9:20–27

God answered Daniel's prayer right away by sending Gabriel, his messenger, to explain Daniel's vision. Gabriel's explanation included both the near and distant future of Daniel's people.

Daniel 9:21

- Gabriel ... earlier vision: See Daniel 8:15–16.
- evening sacrifice: Before the temple's destruction, Israel offered two sacrificial lambs daily. They offered one in the morning and one in the evening (Exodus 29:41). Daniel likely prayed at these times each day (Daniel 6:10, 13; compare Psalm 55:17).

Daniel 9:22

In the book of Daniel, insight and understanding often refer to the meaning of God's revelation (compare Daniel 1:4; 9:13, 25; 11:33, 35). God did not promise Daniel answers to all his questions. Instead, God gave him a basic understanding of the issues. God controls history.

Daniel 9:23

- an answer when out: This command might have been God's order to end the exile in Babylon and bring his people back to Jerusalem and Judea. It could also have been the command to reveal the future to Daniel (Daniel 9:24–27).
- you are highly precious: Also in Daniel 10:11, 19.
- It is unclear what the vision refers to:
- It could be the restoration of Jerusalem and God's people that Daniel read about in Jeremiah and envisioned in his prayer (Daniel 9:2–20), or
- one of the earlier visions (for example, Daniel 8; compare 8:27).

Daniel 9:24

- Many people interpret the seventy sets of seven as seventy "weeks of years," meaning 490 years. However, the Hebrew text does not call them "years," making it hard to match this period to a historical 490 years. So, many believe these numbers symbolize time periods needed to fulfill the visions. Just as Jerusalem faced a long period of desolation (Daniel 9:2; see study note on Jeremiah 25:11), the city would also have many periods of restoration.
- The time period was for the Jewish people and Jerusalem. The six purposes listed seem to focus on restoring the Jews and Jerusalem. Some think these purposes show God's work of redemption worldwide.
- God would end the rebellion of the Israelites and also the rebellions of rulers who defy him and attack his people (Daniel 7:8, 22, 25–26; 8:13–14; 11:29–45).
- To confirm the prophetic vision means to fulfill the answer to Daniel's prayer.
- the Most Holy Place (or the Most Holy One; literally a most holy): Some think this refers to the restored Most Holy Place in the temple in 164 BC. Others believe it refers to the anointing of Christ and his church as God's temple (Matthew 12:6; Ephesians 2:19–22).

Daniel 9:24–27

Gabriel further explained the meaning of Daniel's vision (Daniel 9:22–23). Since the vision in Daniel 8 ends with Antiochus IV (see Daniel 8:23–25; compare 11:21–39), many interpreters think this explanation also refers to Antiochus. Others believe it ends with the death of Christ, followed by the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 and the arrival of the antichrist.

Daniel 9:25

- The command to rebuild Jerusalem and its temple starts the seventy sets of seven. The event that best matches this is Cyrus the Great's decree in 538 BC, which allowed the Jews to return to Jerusalem and start rebuilding (see Daniel 5:31; 9:1; Ezra 1:2–4). Less likely are the decrees of Artaxerxes I in 458 BC (see Ezra 7:12–26) and 445 BC (see Nehemiah 2:5–8).
- the Messiah, the Prince: Many interpreters believe Christ fulfills this prophecy, viewing this passage as covering history from Daniel's time to Christ's time.

However, a Messiah can refer to any of Israel's kings or priests, who were anointed with oil. If fulfilled during Antiochus IV's time, the anointed one was likely the high priest then, Onias III (compare Daniel 11:22).

- a trench: The vision describes Jerusalem being physically rebuilt. The Jews finished rebuilding the temple's in 515 BC (Ezra 3:1–6:22). In 445 BC, Nehemiah completed Jerusalem's wall (Nehemiah 2–6).
- The times of distress may refer to Jerusalem and its temple's history from the decree's publication until the end of the seventy sets of seven (see Daniel 11:2–45).

Daniel 9:26

- the Messiah (literally an anointed): Those who see this prophecy fulfilled in the time of Antiochus IV point to the murder of the high priest Onias III in 171 BC as its fulfillment (see study note on Daniel 11:22). Those who see the fulfillment in the time of Christ understand this prophecy to refer to the crucifixion of the Messiah in AD 30 or 33.
- The ruler who will arise might refer to Antiochus IV. He tried to destroy the Jewish people and their temple worship between 171 and 164 BC (see 1 Maccabees 1:20–40). However, many think the destruction of the city and the temple refers to Jerusalem's destruction by the Romans in AD 66–70.
- The end refers to the completion of the seventy sets of seven. The text suggests that the very end is a later time and that the war would continue into the future (compare Matthew 24:4–8; Mark 13:5–8).
- The image of a flood often represents an invading army (compare Daniel 11:10, 22, 40; Nahum 1:8) or devastating destruction.

Daniel 9:27

- he: Most interpreters think this pronoun refers to the ruler in Daniel 9:26. Some believe it refers to the anointed one in Daniel 9:25–26, suggesting a prophecy about Christ. They say Christ made a covenant and ended the need for sacrifices through his death.

However, the term for making a treaty implies forcing a covenant, likely through intimidation. Antiochus IV forced a covenant with Judea's people when he began ruling in 175 BC (compare Daniel 11:23; see 1 Maccabees 1:10–15). Other interpreters think this prophecy was fulfilled in AD 66–70. Some believe it refers to a future ruler.

- The phrase put an end means a destructive action, not an act of salvation like the Messiah's death. In 167 BC, Antiochus IV ordered Judea's people to stop Jewish worship in the temple and practice pagan worship under threat of death (see 1 Maccabees 1:41–63). Similarly, Roman general Titus ended sacrifices in the temple by destroying it in AD 70.
- the abomination that causes desolation (literally an abomination of desolation): Compare Daniel 8:13; 11:31; 12:11. This term (Hebrew shiqqutsim meshomem) might mock the Semitic name for Zeus (Ba'al Shamayim, "Lord of the Heavens"). Idol-gods are often called shiqquts, "abomination," "desolation," in the Bible (see Deuteronomy 29:17; 2 Chronicles 15:8; Isaiah 66:3; Jeremiah 32:34; Ezekiel 20:7), and the sound similarity between shomem, "devastation, destruction, desolation," and shamayim is clear.

In December 167 BC, Antiochus IV placed a Zeus statue on the temple altar and sacrificed unclean animals there. The same phrase (abomination of desolation) describes that altar and its sacrifices in 1 Maccabees 1:54. Jesus and several New Testament authors predicted a future desolating sacrilege (Matthew 24:15; Mark 13:14; Luke 21:20; 2 Thessalonians 2:3–4).

After Titus destroyed the Jerusalem temple in AD 70, the Romans placed their idols in the temple area and made sacrifices to their gods (see Josephus, War 6.6.1). The apostle John noted that many antichrists had appeared (1 John 2:18–23) and that the antichrist's spirit was active in the world (1 John 4:3).

- The time of destruction is under God's control, and the fate of this defiler is certain (compare Daniel 7:11; 8:25; 11:45). This is true for every ruler who opposes God and tries to destroy God's people.

Daniel 10:1

- In the third year of King Cyrus's reign, which was 536 BC, Cyrus allowed people to return to their ancestral homes (2 Chronicles 36:22–23; Ezra 1:1–2). Daniel's prayer (Daniel 9:4–19) was answered, and the exile in Babylon ended.
- Belteshazzar: See Daniel 1:7.

Daniel 10:1–12.13

This final vision spans from 536 BC to a future when Daniel will rise from the dead and receive his inheritance. All earthly kingdoms will be destroyed. The eternal kingdom of the Son of Man will arise. God's people will finally be rescued, and death, the ultimate enemy, will be defeated.

Daniel 10:2–3

Daniel seemed to be in mourning because of his earlier visions (Daniel 10:14, 16).

Daniel 10:5–6

The man in linen clothing is an unknown messenger of the Lord (compare Daniel 10:16, 18; 12:6–7; see also Ezekiel 9:3).

Daniel 10:7–9

Daniel reacted like most people do when they see heavenly beings (compare Joshua 5:14; Isaiah 6:5; Acts 9:7–9; Revelation 1:17).

Daniel 10:11

highly precious: See also Daniel 9:23; 10:19.

Daniel 10:13

- the prince of the kingdom: Spiritual forces behind different nations, like the spirit prince of Persia or Greece, blocked the way of God's messenger who responded to the prayers of God's people (see Daniel 10:20–11:1).
- one of the chief princes: An archangel is a chief among God's heavenly messengers.
- Daniel's world, and ours, has more than what we can see. Daniel learns that history's great events happen against a real spiritual backdrop. In this world, spiritual beings either support or hinder God's people, and age-old conflicts play out. Behind everything, the Ancient of Days guides all things and judges the process and its outcome.

God's covenant with his people and their relationship with him through prayer are central. The world is not ultimately governed by angels and spirit princes, but by the Ancient of Days, who hears his people's prayers.

Daniel 10:16

touched my lips: Compare Exodus 4:11–12; Isaiah 6:5–7.

Daniel 10:19

God's word provides strength to his servants (compare Psalms 29:11; 68:35).

Daniel 10:20

The messenger explained empires by describing the spirit prince that represented each one. The Persian Empire had just begun and would later be replaced by the Greek Empire (compare Daniel 8:3–7, 19–21).

Daniel 10:21

- Book of Truth (literally writing of truth): The messenger spoke not of himself but from what was written in God's Book of Truth. Compare God's book in Daniel 7:9–10; Exodus 32:32–33. See also Daniel 12:1; Psalm 139:16. The Book of Truth contains what is revealed in Daniel 11:2–12:7.
- against these, except Michael your prince: God divided the nations and assigned them their princes (Deuteronomy 32:8). God was over Israel, and Michael was Israel's spirit prince.

Daniel 11:1

Darius the Mede: See study note on Daniel 5:31. Darius's first year was likely 539 BC.

Daniel 11:2

Three more kings: The Persian kings who followed Cyrus II were most likely:

- Cambyses, who ruled from 530 to 522 BC,
- Gaumata, who ruled in 522 BC and was a usurper, and
- Darius I, who ruled from 521 to 486 BC.

The fourth was probably Xerxes I, who ruled from 486 to 465 BC (see study note on Esther 1:1). Xerxes was famous for his wealth, his army of 1,700,000 soldiers, and his large navy (see Herodotus, Histories 7.6). He used these forces to fight against Greece, but did not succeed. The Persians could not defeat Greece's growing power. God's guiding hand influenced the historical events in this chapter.

Daniel 11:2–12.7

The messenger shared a broad overview of history. It started with Persia, continued through the fall of Greece, and covered the rise and fall of a wicked king or several kings (Daniel 11:21–45). It concluded with the final resurrection and victory of God's people.

Daniel 11:3

Alexander the Great was a powerful king (see study note on Daniel 8:21) who ruled from 336 to 323 BC. He conquered much of the known world in thirteen years, from Greece to India and from the north to Egypt in the south.

Daniel 11:4

- Alexander died on June 10, 323 BC, in Babylon when he was 33 years old. He was at the height of his power and wanted to be worshiped as a god.
- Alexander's descendants could not govern, and his brother Philip was not capable.
- because his kingdom will be ... given to others: Several of Alexander's generals divided his empire. By 301 BC, their conflicts had divided it into four parts (see Daniel 7:4–7; 8:8–12 and Daniel 7:7–7; 8:8–12). God guides history, and its end belongs to him.

Daniel 11:5

The first king of the south was Ptolemy I Soter, who ruled from 323 to 285 BC. One of his officials, Seleucus I Nicator, took control of Syria and ruled from 321 to 281 BC. Both were military commanders under Alexander the Great. At first, the Ptolemies controlled Palestine from 320 to 198 BC.

Daniel 11:5–45

In this passage, the king of the South refers to Alexander's general Ptolemy and his descendants, who ruled Egypt. The king of the North refers to Alexander's general Seleucus and his descendants, who ruled Syria and Mesopotamia.

After Alexander's death, the kings of Egypt and Syria fought for control of Palestine, a strategically important land. The holy city and its people were caught between these two powers. These battles continued until their predetermined end (Daniel 11:27, 35, 40, 45; 12:1, 7).

Historical accounts of these events appear in 1, 2, and 3 Maccabees and in the works of Herodotus, Livy, Polybius, Porphyry, and Josephus.

Daniel 11:6

Antiochus II Theos was the king of the north, who ruled from 261 to 246 BC. Ptolemy II Philadelphus was the king of the south, who ruled from 284 to 246 BC. They formed an alliance. In 250 BC, Antiochus married Ptolemy's daughter, Berenice Syra, but abandoned her in 246 BC. Later, both she and Antiochus were murdered.

Daniel 11:7–8

one from her family line: Berenice's brother Ptolemy III Euergetes, became king of the south from 246 to 221 BC. He invaded Syria with his army, defeated the king of the north, Seleucus II Callinicus, who ruled from 246 to 226 BC, and occupied the fortress cities of Antioch and Seleucia. He expanded the Ptolemaic kingdom to its greatest size. When he returned to Egypt, he took their idols with him but left Seleucus II on the throne.

Daniel 11:9

Seleucus II, the king of the north, attempted to invade Egypt in 242 BC but Ptolemy III defeated him.

Daniel 11:10–12

- The sons of Seleucus II were:
- Seleucus III Ceraunus, who ruled from 226 to 223 BC, and
- Antiochus III the Great, who ruled from 223 to 187 BC.
- a great army ... sweeping through like a flood: Antiochus III aggressively tried to reclaim lost lands, including Palestine.
- as far as his fortress: Antiochus III advanced to Raphia, near Egypt's border, in 217 BC. In the battle that followed, the king of the south, Ptolemy IV Philopater, who ruled from 221 to 203 BC, defeated Antiochus III and kept control of Palestine.

Daniel 11:12–13

- Ptolemy IV's success did not last long. In 198 BC, Antiochus III, the king of the north, returned.
- Antiochus III had been conquering lands to the north and east. From these lands, he raised a fully equipped army that was much larger than before (compare 3 Maccabees 1:1–5).

Daniel 11:14

- A general uprising of Jews and rebel Egyptians who supported Antiochus III occurred. The king of the south was Ptolemy V Epiphanes, who ruled from 203 to 181 BC.
- they will fail: The Egyptian commander, Scopas, stopped the rebellion in 200 BC.

Daniel 11:15

In 198 BC at Paneas, King Antiochus III of the north defeated Egyptian General Scopas. He besieged and captured Sidon, a fortified city, and took control of Palestine.

Daniel 11:16

with destruction in his hand: Antiochus III tried to make the Jews adopt Greek culture and abandon their ancient customs. However, some Jews welcomed him, and he responded by giving them special privileges. He allowed them to live according to their own laws.

His son, Antiochus IV, did not treat them this way (Daniel 11:21–39).

Daniel 11:17

Antiochus III allied with Ptolemy V by giving his daughter, Cleopatra I, to him in marriage. Antiochus wanted to take over Egypt from within. However, his plan failed when Cleopatra became loyal to Egypt. Egypt then allied with Rome.

Daniel 11:18

Antiochus III expanded his territory to include the coastlands of Anatolia, Macedonia, and Greece. However, the Romans defeated him in 191 and 190 BC. The prince was the well-known Roman general Scipio. He stopped the expansion of Antiochus III and forced him to give up the lands he had taken in the west and return in shame.

Daniel 11:19

After this, Antiochus III stayed within his own fortresses. He was killed there in 187 BC by local people rebelling against him.

Daniel 11:20

Antiochus III's successor was his son Seleucus IV Philopater, who ruled from 187 to 175 BC. He was known for sending Heliodorus, a tax collector, to collect large sums of money. This money was needed to maintain royal splendor and pay the heavy tribute imposed by Rome. Heliodorus tried to steal from the temple in Jerusalem but was stopped by divine intervention (see 2 Maccabees 3:1–40). Heliodorus murdered Seleucus after a short seven-year reign.

Daniel 11:21–39

Antiochus IV Epiphanes came to power next, ruling from 175 to 163 BC. He is the small horn mentioned in Daniel 8:9–14, 23–26. His story is vividly described in 1 Maccabees 1:7–6:16; 2 Maccabees 1:1–10:5; 4 Maccabees 4:15–18:5. Antiochus was considered despicable because he seized the throne and for his actions as king. He was not in line for royal succession and took the throne from his brother's son.

Daniel 11:22

The prince of the covenant was Onias III, the high priest (see study notes on Daniel 9:25–26). Antiochus IV removed him in 175 BC and replaced him with his brother Jason (2 Maccabees 4:7–10). In 171 BC, Menelaus murdered Onias and became high priest from 171 to 162 BC. Menelaus supported Antiochus IV's plan to spread Greek culture (see study note on Daniel 9:27).

Daniel 11:23

he will act deceitfully: Antiochus IV made false promises to introduce Greek religion into Judea. Lawless followers supported his policies (see 1 Maccabees 1:11–15).

Daniel 11:24

the richest provinces: Antiochus IV took the temple's riches, demanded large payments from Jerusalem, and placed troops there (1 Maccabees 1:29–40).

Daniel 11:25–27

Ptolemy VI Philometor ruled from 181 to 146 BC. He was the king of the South. Antiochus IV attacked Egypt twice between 170 and 168 BC (1 Maccabees 1:17–19).

Daniel 11:28

In 170 BC, Antiochus IV attacked Jerusalem and the temple. He killed thousands and enslaved many others (1 Maccabees 1:20–42; 2 Maccabees 5:1–23). His arrogance was great (1 Maccabees 1:24–25; compare Daniel 7:28; 8:9).

Daniel 11:29–35

- Antiochus IV invaded the south (Egypt) again (see Polybius, Histories 29.1).
- The warships from western coastlands refer to the Romans. The Roman general Popilius Laenas drew a circle in the sand, made Antiochus stand inside it, and forced him to decide whether to return home or prepare for war with Rome before leaving the circle.

Fearing the Roman fleet, Antiochus chose to withdraw and return home. He then took out his anger and humiliation on the Jews, the people of the holy covenant. He captured Jerusalem in 167 BC and rewarded those who joined him. He defiled the altar (see Daniel 8:9–14, 23–26), stopped the sacrifices, set up a statue of the Greek god Zeus in the temple, and persecuted and killed those who refused to abandon the covenant (see 1 Maccabees 1:62–64; compare Daniel 9:27; Matthew 24:15).

Daniel 11:31

the abomination of desolation: See study note on Daniel 9:27.

Daniel 11:32–35

Wise people know God and his laws and follow them, even in a hostile and deceptive environment. Many were killed for their faithfulness to God and his laws during this time (1 Maccabees 1:11; Daniel 7:19; 2 Maccabees 6–7).

Daniel 11:34

Help arrived when Mattathias's family and their supporters (the Maccabees) started a national revolt. Antiochus was busy elsewhere and could not stop it. In 164 BC, three years after the temple was desecrated, the Maccabees recaptured Jerusalem. They removed the statue of Zeus, cleansed the altar, and restored daily sacrifices (Daniel 8:11–14, 26; 1 Maccabees 1:59). This event is celebrated during Hanukkah (see John 10:22).

Daniel 11:36

- Antiochus IV considered himself equal to God (2 Maccabees 9:1–10:12), but God restrained him until the time of wrath ended.
- what has been decreed must be accomplished: Antiochus suddenly developed a painful disease and died in 163 BC in the mountains of Persia (see Daniel 8:25; 1 Maccabees 4:52–53; 6:16; 2 Maccabees 9:4, 28; 10:5).

Daniel 11:36–40

Some interpreters see these verses as a transition from the earthly Antiochus IV to a figure who is larger than history itself (Daniel 7:8).

Daniel 11:37–38

- no regard for the gods of his father: He abandoned the Syrian gods to worship Greek gods.
- The one desired by women might be a Canaanite or Egyptian fertility deity.
- History does not mention a god of fortresses, but this might refer to the lavish gifts Antiochus gave to cities and Greek temples. He might have done this to improve his reputation and power (see Livy, History 41.20).

Daniel 11:40

No known southern or northern king did these actions.

Daniel 11:40–45

Most commentators believe these verses describe the end of history (compare Mark 13:14; 2 Thessalonians 2:3–12; Revelation 19:19–21). These verses reflect the actions of Antiochus IV, but there is no historical record of these events. Antiochus serves as a model for future rulers who oppose the God of gods.

Daniel 11:41

- the Beautiful Land: Israel (compare Daniel 8:9; 11:16) is once more the target of an evil king's attack.
- Moab, Edom, and Ammon were nations that surrounded ancient Israel and Judah.

Daniel 11:45

- The holy mountain includes Zion, Jerusalem, and the temple, where God chose for his name to dwell.
- The sea likely refers to the Mediterranean Sea.

Daniel 12:1

- Michael was the angel who protected Israel (see Daniel 10:13, 21; Revelation 2:1, 8, 12).
- the book: This might be the Book of Truth (Daniel 10:21; see 7:10).
- will be delivered: All past rescues of God's people in Daniel (for example, Daniel 3:28; 6:27) hinted at and now lead to the resurrection from the dead (12:2–3).

Daniel 12:1–7

In the end times, God will save his people and defeat all enemies, including death.

Daniel 12:2

Everlasting life is entirely free from shame or disgrace (compare Genesis 2:25; 3:7).

Daniel 12:3

- Wise people know their God (compare Daniel 1:4, 17; 8:25; 9:22, 25; 11:32–35; 12:10).
- To shine is a common metaphor for life, purity, righteousness, and glory.

Daniel 12:4

Daniel had to keep the prophecy a secret (compare Daniel 7:28; 8:26). God would reveal it at the right time, at the end.

Daniel 12:5

- The river was the Tigris River (Daniel 10:4).
- Two others confirmed God's promises (see Numbers 35:30; Deuteronomy 19:15).

Daniel 12:7

- a time, and times, and half a time: God sets times for everything as he controls earthly and heavenly events (see study note on Daniel 7:24–25).

- The breaking of the holy people was part of God's plan to purify them (Daniel 12:10).

Daniel 12:8–10

- God did not reveal exactly how and when everything would end. Daniel would not witness the end (Daniel 12:13); his task was to live his life with faith.
- purified, made spotless, and refined: God would use violent and terrifying times to improve the moral and religious character of his people (compare Daniel 11:35).
- Being wise means understanding God's ways and living by them. The wicked will not understand or change their ways, even if someone explains the vision to them.

Daniel 12:11–12

- the abomination of desolation: See Daniel 8:13–14, 23–26; 11:29–35. See also study note on Daniel 9:27.
- God's people must wait and stay faithful when the end times come.
- 1,290 days ... 1,335 days: Some interpreters think these numbers relate to events during the reign of Antiochus IV Epiphanes. Others believe they are symbolic.

The number 1,290 equals 43 lunar months of 30 days each, which is about three and a half years in the solar calendar. This might represent the final half of the last "set of seven" (Daniel 9:27).
The number 1,335 might mean an extra 45 days of waiting until the end. Those who endure the entire time, and then some, will see God act for his people.

Daniel 12:13

Daniel died before the end times, but he knew he would rise again. The end times refer to when even the dead rise (Daniel 12:1–3) and God's everlasting kingdom is established.